



7

VOLUME
SEVEN

ABYSSAL

LOOM OF THE DEPTHS

BEYOND
PRESSURE.
BEYOND
SANITY.
WE BECOME
THE TETHER.



STORY
DEREK NOBLE

ART
CELIA CALDERON

WORLD
N.T. LOCKHART

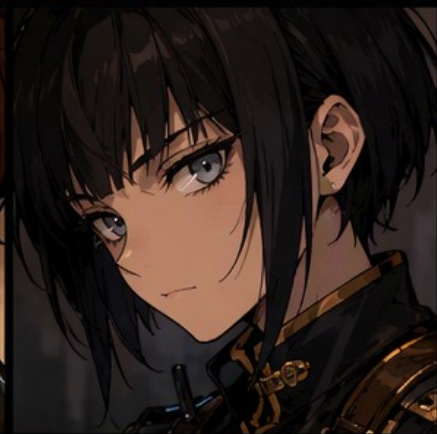


WE DON'T
KNOW WHAT'S
OUT THERE.

BUT
WHATEVER
IT IS...



...WE'LL
FACE IT
TOGETHER.



THAT'S
ENOUGH.



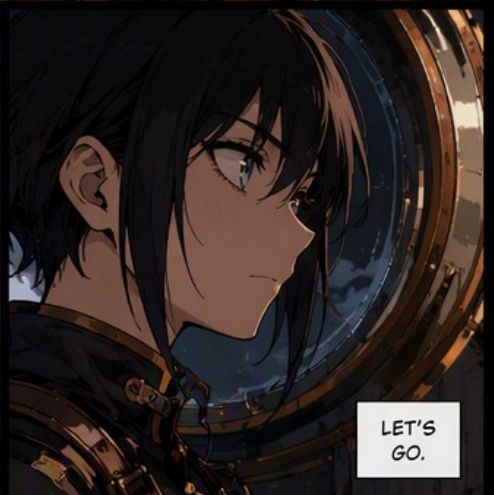
THREE
FOOLS.

ONE SHIP.



THE MANTA
WAITS.

SO DO WE.



LET'S
GO.



THE MANTA
CHAPTER 7: THRESHOLD



LORD-WARDEN VALERIUS

ANCHORITE VANGUARD
FLEET COMMANDER

"Duty is not a burden.
It is the shape
of our devotion."



THE VANGUARD
AWAITS YOUR
WORD,
MY LORD.

GOOD.

LET THEM
WAIT A LITTLE
LONGER.

PRECISION
IS BORNE OF
PATIENCE.



THIRD FLEET ARRAY,
ADJUST BEARING
TWO POINT FIVE
DEGREES STARBOARD.

MAINTAIN SILENT
RUNNING.

WE ARE SHADOW
BEFORE DAWN.



COMMENCE
FINAL ORDER
PROTOCOL.

CLNK



TELL THE FLEETS:
WE DO NOT SEEK
GLORY.

WE SECURE
THE FUTURE.



BY ORDER OF
THE ANCHORITE,
BY WILL OF
THE COUNCIL—

HOLD FAST.



ALL VANGUARD
FLEETS,
FORMATION
ETERNAL ANCHOR.

EXECUTE
AS WRITTEN.
SO IT IS.



THE SPINDLE
AWAITS.

AND WE ARE
ITS BULWARK.
SO IT IS.



FAR BELOW THE
CONVERGING FLEETS,
WHERE PRESSURE
SCULPTS SILENCE...

...SHE WAITS.

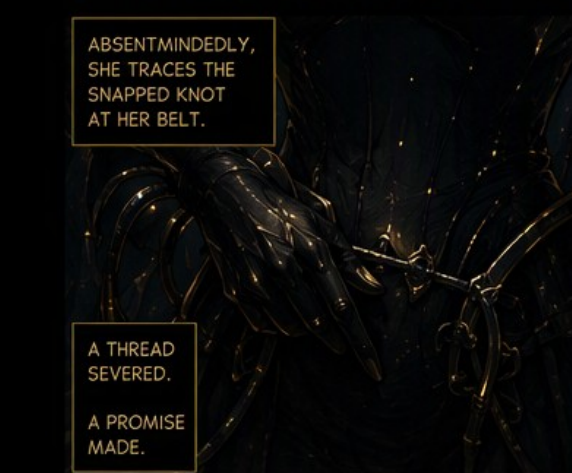


MOTHER BATHYAL.

SOVEREIGN OF THE UNDERTOW.
KEEPER OF DEPTHS THAT
REMEMBER.

HER VEIL HIDES WHAT
SHOULD NOT BE SEEN.

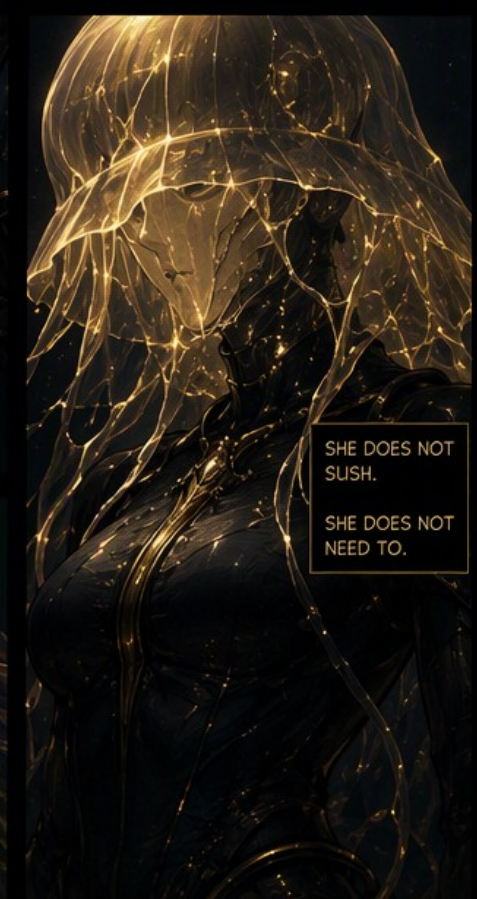
HER PRESENCE REMINDS
WHAT CANNOT BE
AVERTED.



ABSENTMINDEDLY,
SHE TRACES THE
SNAPPED KNOT
AT HER BELT.

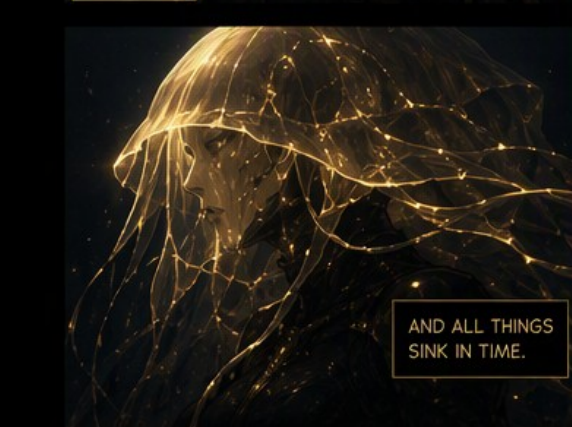
A THREAD
SEVERED.

A PROMISE
MADE.



SHE DOES NOT
SUSH.

SHE DOES NOT
NEED TO.



FOR SHE KNOWS—



THE CURRENT ALWAYS
RETURNS TO ITS SOURCE.

THE MANTA

OUTER CONCOURSE

SOME PULSES
DON'T JUST ECHO.

THEY REMEMBER.

HRM-
THERE.

THAT'S
NEW.

STRANGE
RHYTHMIC
PULSE...

INTERVAL
CONSISTENT.

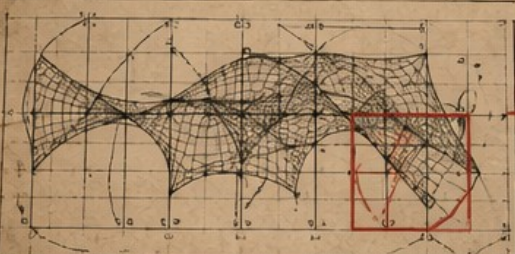
HASE SHIFT
ERRATIC.

GRAVITY-NET SIGNATURES

RECORDED: SEASON ONE CRISIS

SOURCE: BLACKWALL ARCHIVE • REF: GN-77A

*Debris in this pocket
could be lost. Fragments
in the Fractal*



NOTES:

GN-77A
"RENN PATTERN"

- HIGH TENSION
- FAST DEPLOY
- SPORADIC ANCHOR POINTS
- DANGEROUS IN CHAOTIC GRAV FIELDS

EVENT LOG: SEASON ONE CRISIS
TIDAL BELT COLLAPSE • 1122.7.8

RENN

MATCHES.

IT MATCHES
THE GN-77A...

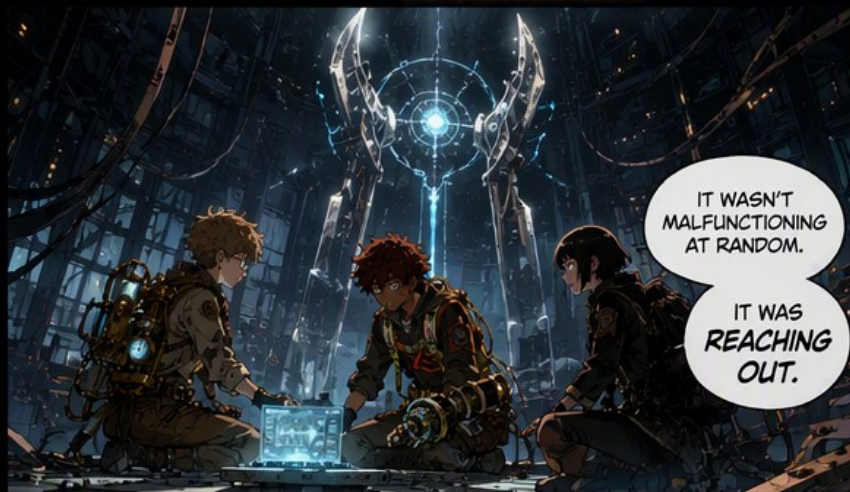
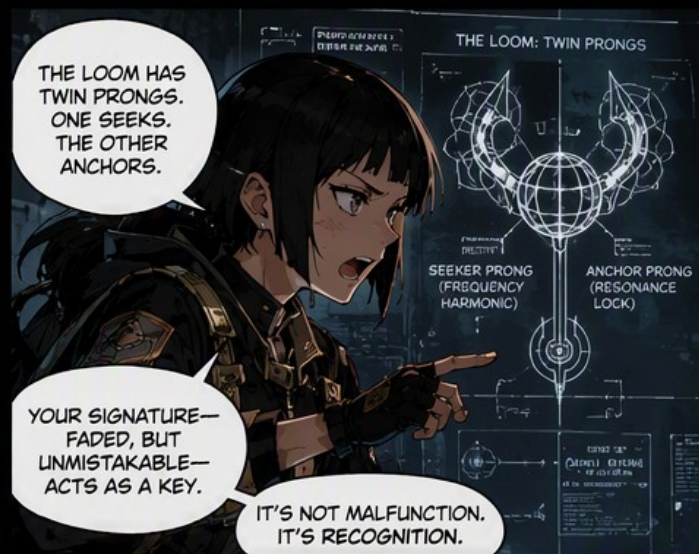
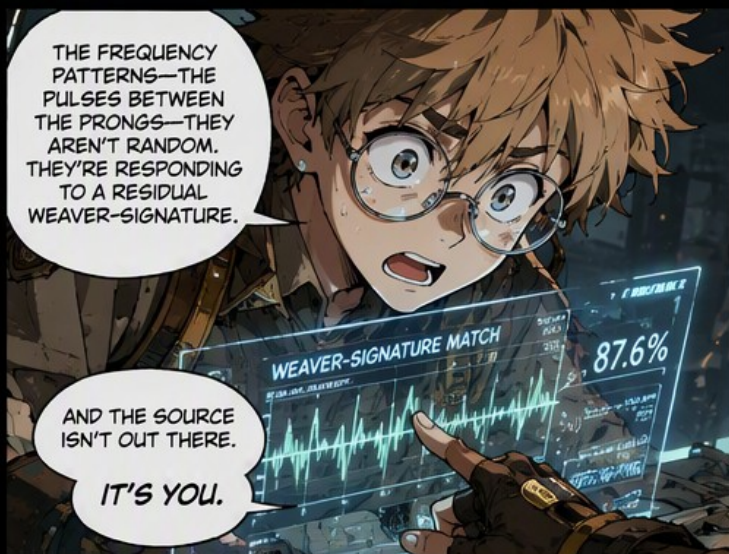
RENN.

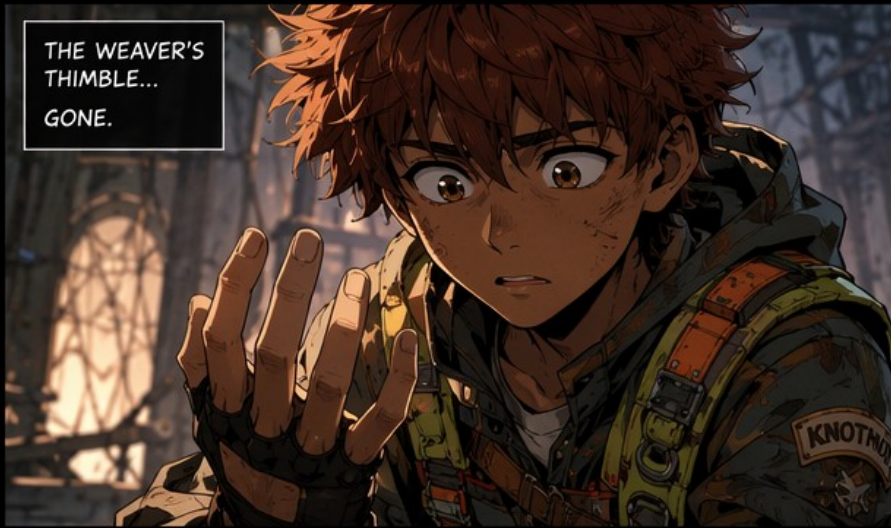
TENSION-GAUNTLET
SPOOL MASTER.
NET RUNNER.
CHAOS CHILD.

...THAT'S
RENN!

BUT...
BUT HE'S—
HE CAN'T
BE HERE!

! GN-77A CONFIRMED
ACTIVE.





THE WEAVER'S
THIMBLE...
GONE.



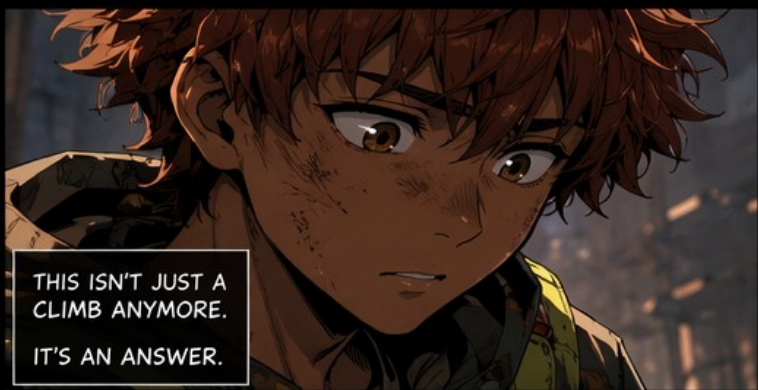
RESTORED.

NORMAL.
EMPTY.

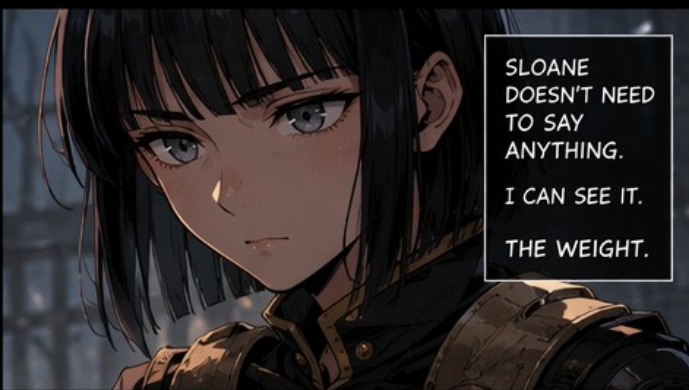


THE LOOM
STILL CALLS.
BUT I HAVE
NO THIMBLE.

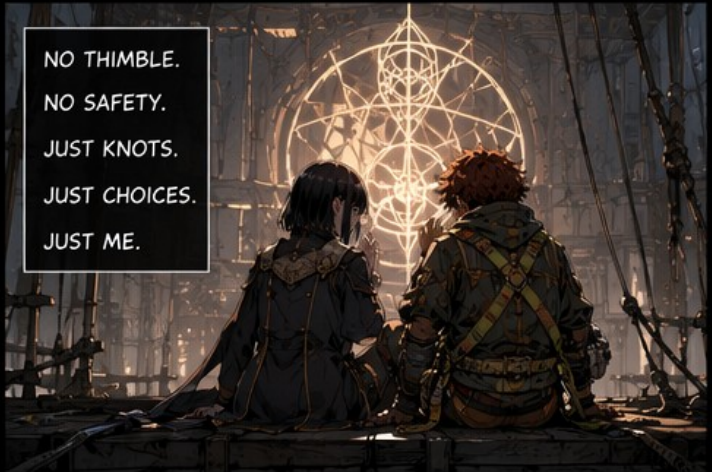
ONLY WHAT
I LEARNED.
FROM THE
KNOTMASTER.



THIS ISN'T JUST A
CLIMB ANYMORE.
IT'S AN ANSWER.



SLOANE
DOESN'T NEED
TO SAY
ANYTHING.
I CAN SEE IT.
THE WEIGHT.



NO THIMBLE.
NO SAFETY.
JUST KNOTS.
JUST CHOICES.
JUST ME.



THEN THAT'S
HOW I'LL
ANSWER.
I'LL CLIMB
MY WAY.

THE LOOM.

TWIN PRONGS OF THE ANCIENTS.
STATUS: RESPONDING.

...THUM
...THUM
...THUM...

CLOSER
THAN THE MAPS
PROMISED.

IT KNOWS
WE'RE HERE.

GOOD.
LET IT.

THIS ISN'T
A GREETING.

IT'S A
RECKONING.

I-I CAN
FEEL IT
THINKING.

LIKE A
HEART THAT'S
OLDER THAN
TIME...

LOOK AT
THE SIZE
OF IT...

THE PULSES...
IT'S SYNCING
WITH OUR
APPROACH.

EVERY BEAT
IS A QUESTION.

THEN WE'D
BETTER HAVE
SOME ANSWERS.

STEADY
YOURSELVES.
WE'RE ALMOST
THERE.

THE LOOM WAITS.
AND IT REMEMBERS.

Lord-Warden
VALERIUS

Anchorite Vanguard



KRRK--

This is
Lord-Warden Valerius
of the Anchorite Vanguard.

You are within consecrated
space. I urge you—stand
aside and allow the Vanguard
to secure the foundation
properly.

It is neither safe
nor wise to interfere.

--KRRK

You will
find no greater ally
here than order.

Order, huh?

Funny way of saying
"trespass."

This isn't
consecrated.

It's scavenged.

I—I don't
think he can
hear us...

It's just...
the relay.

Then let
me be clear.

By decree of High Anchorite
Hestian, this site is forgewrought
in purpose. Interference will be
recorded as heresy.

Stand aside.

For your own
sake.

KRRK--

--KRRK



LORD-WARDEN VALERIUS
ANCHORITE VANGUARD
WARDEN OF THE HIGH SPINDLE

Children.

This path is not
yours. Step aside
quietly, and you will
be returned to your
homes with no
punishment.

I would prefer
that.



We are not
children.

This spindle
is already
taken.



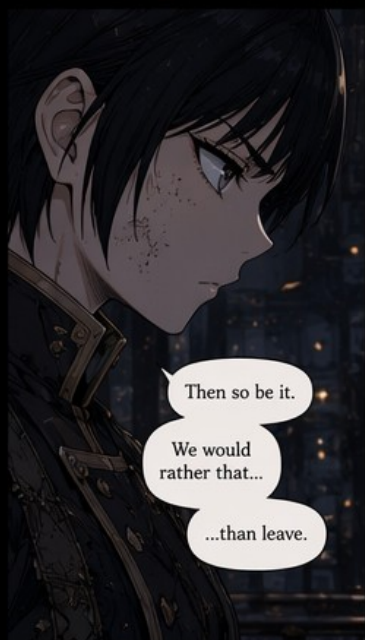
We will
not move.



I do not
understand.

The spindle
is under quarantine.

There is nothing
for you here but
sickness and death.



Then so be it.

We would
rather that...

...than leave.



SO FAR ABOVE.
SO FAR APART.



Very well.

I will grant you
a final mercy.

Stand clear
when the descent
begins.

MOTHER BATHYAL

THE LOOM BELOW

SHE DESCENDS
NOT WITH HASTE,
BUT WITH PURPOSE.

THE LOOM PULSES.
AND SO DO WE.

HER SUIT CIRCULATES
THE LIQUEFIED
ATMOSPHERE—

HER UNDERTOW
LIEUTENANTS
FAN OUT—

SILENT.

THE LOOM'S BASE
DRAWS NEARER.

WE ANSWER.

NOT AIR,
BUT GOLD.

THE CURRENT BOWS.
THE DEPTHS WATCH.
MOTHER BATHYAL
LEADS.



UNDERTOW

JUNO

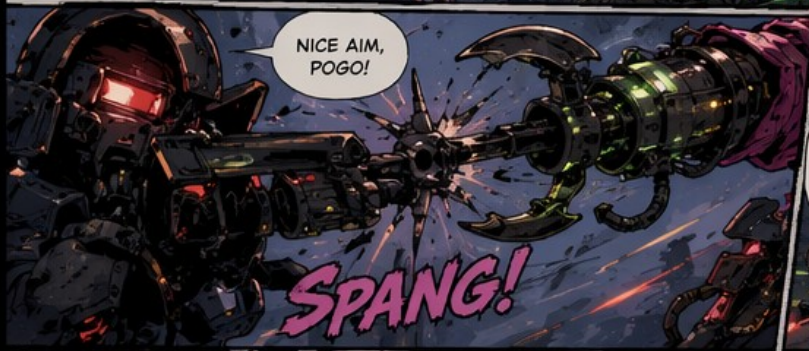
"THE HOOK"
+
"PATCHWORK"
POGO

JUNO "THE HOOK".
FORTY-SOMETHING.
EX-CLIPPER RIGGER.
NOW: OUTER PERIMETER
SPECIALIST.

"PATCHWORK" POGO.
FIFTEEN.
MECHANIC. GENIUS.
WORRY-WART.
ESSENTIAL.

TOGETHER WE
DEFEND THE FLEET'S
OUTER PERIMETER
FROM UNDERTOW
SCOUTS.

NOT GLORY.
JUST JOB.
KEEP THE LINE.
KEEP EVERYONE
ALIVE.



JUNO "THE HOOK"
EX-SYNDICATE CLIMBER.
DREADNOUGHT SALVAGER.
ONE ARM. ALL HUSTLE.

DON'T LET
HER GET ABOVE
YOU!

DREADNOUGHT
SALVAGE & HAULAGE

HSSSSS

WELL WELL WELL.
LOOK WHO FINALLY
DECIDED TO SHOW.

JUNO "THE HOOK".
STILL SWINGIN' SOLO?
OR JUST TRYIN' TO
IMPRESS DADDY'S
CORPSE?

SYNDICATE

IS THAT WHAT
THEY CALL ME
NOW?

KRAK!

HEH.
SAME OLD
JUNO.
TOO SLOW
TO LET GO.

MAYBE.

BUT OLD
HABITS...

DIE HARD.

SOME NAMES
YOU OUTGROW.
OTHERS,
YOU EARN.

JUNO
"THE HOOK"

CLIMBER.
MECHANIC.
PROBLEM SOLVER.
MOSTLY PROBLEM.

A.K.A. THE REASON
PEOPLE CHECK THEIR
ANCHORS TWICE.

NOT MY
FIGHT.

OH, LOOK WHO
FINALLY DECIDED TO
SHOW HER FACE.

STILL RUNNING?
OR JUST TOO SCARED
TO LOSE AGAIN?

ONE ARM, NO HONOR.
HEH. PATHETIC.

OLD RIVAL.
SAME OLD MOUTH.
NOT WORTH THE
AMMO.

NOT
ANYMORE.

MATRON "MAMA" VEX.
MARKET QUEEN.
FEEDS HALF THE SPIRE.
WOULDN'T LET HER DOWN.

KRAAANG!!

LOOSE STRUT.
MAKES A WALL.
SOMETIMES THAT'S
ALL IT TAKES.

NOT EVERY FIGHT
NEEDS YOUR NAME
ON THE WALL.

SOME JUST NEED
A WALL.

THE HELL—?

LEAVE THE ECHOES
TO THE FOOLS.

HOOKE THE ONES
THAT MATTER.

JUNO "THE HOOK"

NOT A HERO.
JUST RELIABLE.



VALERIUS
ABOVE.

BATHYAL
BELOW.

THE LOOM
AHEAD.

NOWHERE
LEFT TO
RUN.



TH-THERE
ARE TOO
MANY...

WE CAN'T
WIN.



YEAH.

PROBABLY.

BUT WE
DON'T GET A
VOTE.



THE LOOM
DOES NOT
NEGOTIATE.

AND NEITHER
DO WE.



WHATEVER
COMES...

WE FACE IT
TOGETHER.



LET THEM
COME.

THE SPINDLE
SEALS.

THE LOOM
AWAKENS.

AND THE GATE
RECEIVES THEM.

WELL,
THAT WAS
A CLOSE
ONE.

LIKE
THREADIN' A
NEEDLE WHILE
IT'S TRYIN' TO
EAT YOU.

FORTUNE
FAVORS
PREPARATION.

NOT
IMPULSIVE
ACROBATICS.

I-I THINK
MY HEART
STOPPED
FIVE TIMES.

B-BUT
WE MADE
IT...

WELCOME
TO THE LOOM'S
HEART.

LET'S HOPE
IT HAS THE
ANSWERS WE
CAME FOR.

BEHIND THEM,
THE SPINDLE
GOES STILL.

A DOOR
CLOSED.

A THREAD
PULLED
TIGHT.

A STORY
CONTINUES.

END OF EPISODE

TO BE CONTINUED...